BIGGEST HITS



↘ TALAASH *(2012)*
Dir: *Reema Kagti*

In the first film they wrote together, what stood out was empathy for flawed characters. An overarching sense of inner turmoil pervaded this mature and riveting drama, which revealed the underbelly of a booming metro and its forgotten denizens.



↘ GULLY BOY *(2019)*
Dir: *Zoya Akhtar*

This tale of an aspiring rapper from Mumbai's fringes came after two films centred on India's upper echelons—*Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* and *Dil Dhadakne Do*. It was to be their most successful project to date with its authentic characters and a winning soundtrack, which included that popular hit that went to become an anthem for Indian youth—'Apna Time Aayega'.

↘ MADE IN HEAVEN *SEASON 1*
Dir: *Alankrita Shrivastava, Nitya Mehra, Zoya Akhtar and Prashant Nair*

A series about two friends from New Delhi who work together as wedding planners became a means for Zoya and Reema to talk about social prejudices. Written in association with Shrivastava, it is a work that offers the most insight into the duo's socio-cultural worldview.



it otherwise," says Zoya—at which Reema rolls her eyes. Whoever comes up with the better argument, wins. Their friend and collaborator Ankur Tewari, with whom they expanded their production house Tiger Baby Films to an eponymous music label titled Tiger Baby Records, says, "It is exciting to witness a discussion where both are equally driven to explain their point. They are not agreeing with each other on everything, and they are comfortable with that.... Both are logic-driven, yet very emotional."

Those wrangling matches have eased down over the years. Not every day is productive. "Sometimes you just gossip and don't do anything," says Zoya. But, she says, "you have to have discipline. There's no muse that comes. You have to sit at it every day." On how they decide who will direct that finished work, Reema says, "We know it way before. When the script is working, the one who is not directing is always like, 'Give it to me, I want to do it'." Both admit that they have at times regretted ceding an exciting project to the other.

Over the past few years, as Zoya and Reema worked on more projects together, they started engaging with other writers too. The first such collaboration was in 2016, shortly after they set up Tiger Baby Films with the aim of becoming creative producers. Alankrita Shrivastava (*Lipstick Under My Burkha*, 2016), with whom they co-wrote *Made in Heaven*, says, "In temperament, they are entirely different. So is their sense of humour. It's an interesting dynamic. There is a sense of debate and discussion with which they function—thinking things through, sticking to your point and letting go when you need to." Shrivastava describes their writer's room as a "democratic space", peppered with laughs, arguments and lots of food. "They are good at harmonising energies, where everyone feels excited, relaxed and respectful of the directorial space. I really respect their work ethic and attention to detail. Every single line is discussed. Nothing is just like that."

For Zoya and Reema, on the other hand, working with other writers whose experiences are entirely different from theirs offers them an opportunity to expand their worldview. In *The Archies*, they worked with Ayesha DeVitre (*Kapoor & Sons*, 2016 and *Gehraiyaan*, 2022), and for Reema's next directorial venture, *Supermen of Malegaon*, they roped in Varun Grover (*Masaan*, 2015) as writer,